

Paul Kiernan

Medium humanoid (engineer), chaotic good

Class & Level Staff Engineer 11 / CTO 3 • Race Human (Variant) • Background Sage (ECE) • Alignment Chaotic Good

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QUEST LOG

Sabbatical — The Long Rest

Nov 2025 – Present

- Taking my first proper rest in fifteen years. Family first, art second, and a slow-burn obsession with what happens to search infrastructure when the query interface starts talking back.
- Happy to trade notes on retrieval, Kafka war stories, or agentic developer tools. Say hi.

Phaselaw — The Startup Forge

Jul 2023 – Nov 2025

Chief Technology Officer

Oct 2024 – Nov 2025

- Architected an AI-powered document review and redaction platform entrusted with highly sensitive legal and personal data—10M+ documents securely redacted for the NHS, Labour (UK), and the Raspberry Pi Foundation
- Built and led the engineering organization; owned hiring, engineering culture, and technical due diligence with investors and partners
- Drove reliability and security practices—CI/CD, automated testing, multi-region infrastructure-as-code—through SOC 2 Type II certification

Founding Backend Engineer

Jul 2023 – Oct 2024

- Designed and built the core backend platform from zero—data models, API layer, auth, and service architecture deployed across multiple global regions
- Made foundational technology choices (language, framework, database, cloud provider), favoring boring, proven technology that let a tiny team ship and operate a global platform

Reddit Inc. — The Front Page Campaign

Jul 2018 – Jul 2023

Staff Software Engineer — Data Engineering & Search

Nov 2019 – Jul 2023

- Tech lead for search indexing (managed 3 engineers, mentored 3 more); owned the Scala/Flink pipeline keeping a multi-billion-document Solr/Lucene index fresh against millions of events per second—the same systems later served all of Reddit's LLM applications
- Unlocked comment search, a capability a decade behind post search—architected the Kafka infrastructure and consumer DAG that made Reddit's largest corpus (7.5M+ new comments/day) searchable within a minute of posting
- Designed the Kafka platform that finally scaled for Reddit: a 5M+ messages/sec event backbone other teams built on for analytics, data warehousing, and subreddit activity notifications

Senior Software Engineer II — Data Infrastructure

Jul 2018 – Nov 2019

- Built event-driven analytics and Kafka-to-BigQuery warehouse ingestion pipelines, replacing poll- and cron-based batch jobs so downstream systems react in seconds rather than hours

Chartbeat Inc. — The Real-Time Chronicles

Aug 2014 – Jul 2018

Head of Backend Engineering

Oct 2016 – Jul 2018

- Forged *MrRoboto*, a replicated C++ key-value store capable of 500k+ writes/sec with LMDB copy-on-write b-tree and Chain Replication
- Forged *Miata*, a real-time streaming analytics framework using Kafka, ZeroMQ, and Python
- Led a party of 8 backend engineers across 4 product teams; conducted weekly 1-on-1s with each party member

Backend Team Lead

Oct 2015 – Oct 2016

- Led R&D team developing experimental products; presented research and new products to the Chartbeat Board

Backend Developer

Aug 2014 – Oct 2015

- Open-sourced *Parselmouth*, an object-oriented interface for abstracting away the ugly parts of ad server APIs

Moat Inc. (acq. Oracle) — The Crawler Dungeons

Jun 2012 – Aug 2014

Software Developer

Jun 2012 – Aug 2014

- Early team member behind Moat Pro, an enterprise ad-intelligence platform for researching trends in online advertising
- Engineered a network of web crawlers for detecting and indexing online advertisements across geographical regions

ABILITY SCORES



PERSONALITY

Traits. 15-year veteran of large-scale distributed systems. Founding engineer to CTO at Phaselaw. Built Reddit's search and streaming infrastructure for 500M+ monthly users. Inventor on US Patent 10,068,250.

Ideals. Do the simple thing that works. Boring technology, deployed carefully, measured honestly.

Bonds. Drawn to small, high-trust teams where rigor serves a mission.

Flaws. Physically incapable of walking past a flaky test.

PROFICIENCIES

Languages

Python • Scala • C++
C • Java • Clojure
Shell • SQL

Data & Infrastructure

Kafka • Flink • Solr
Lucene • BigQuery • ZeroMQ
HAProxy • AWS • Docker
Kubernetes • Terraform
Temporal • ArgoCD
GenAI/LLM pipelines

Familiar

JavaScript • CSS • PHP

BACKSTORY

Cornell University

BS in ECE, 2008–2012
McMullen Dean Scholar
Goldfarb Tradition Fellow
Slope Media VP of Prod.
Nanosat 6 Power Subsystem
Cornell FSAE

SENDING STONES

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